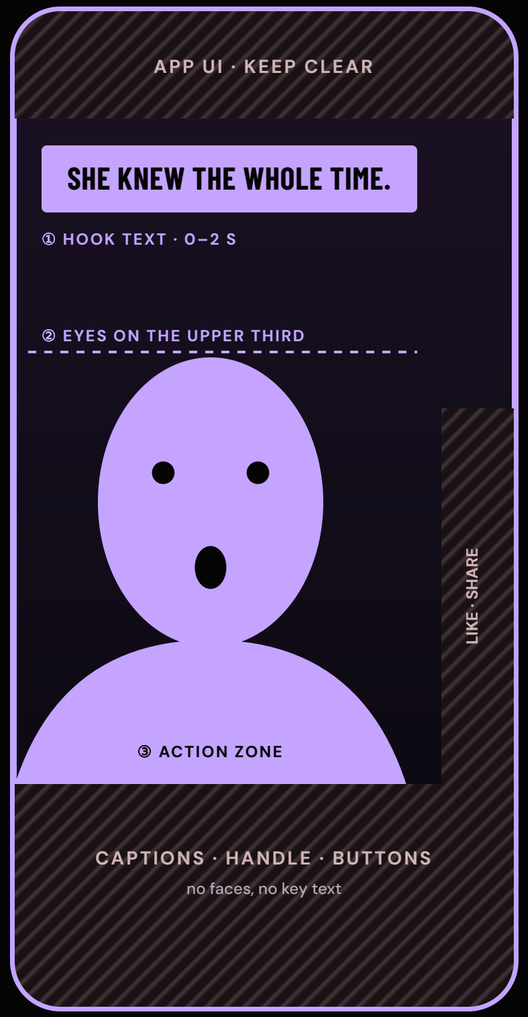
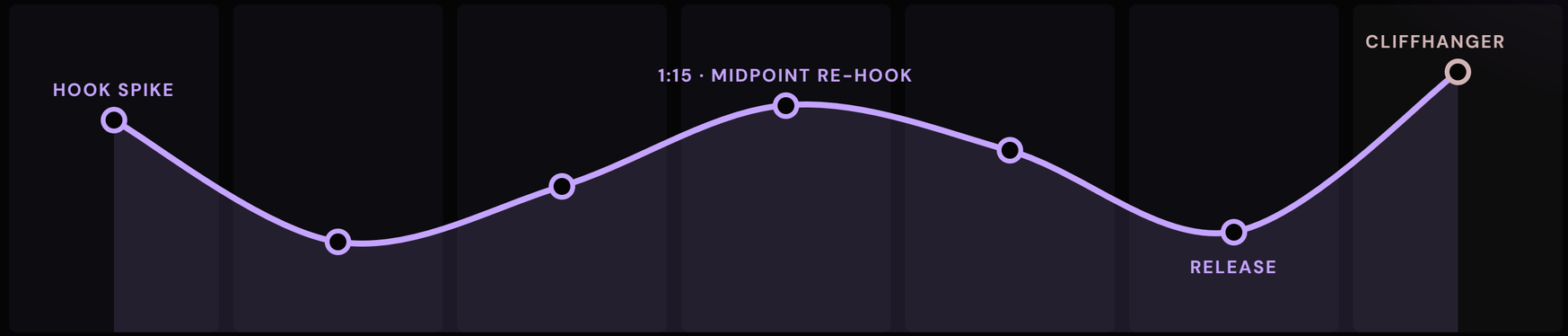
# One episode = one pressure loop

Target **2:30** (range 2:00–3:00) · vertical 9:16 · every episode hooks in 5 seconds, turns at the midpoint, and ends on a question.




Illustrative tension shape, not platform data. Release is allowed, flat is not.

## HOOK
0:00–0:05

**Start mid-action. A face or threat is already in frame 1.**

WRITER RULE

No setup. No establishing shot. One image + one line that raises a question.

## ANCHOR
0:05–0:20

**Who wants what, right now. Where we are.**

WRITER RULE

One recap line so a new viewer can enter here. State the stakes.

## PRESSURE
0:20–0:55

**An obstacle hits. New information lands.**

WRITER RULE

Someone says or does the thing that makes the plan impossible.

## TWIST
0:55–1:30

**Reversal near 1:15. Power flips.**

WRITER RULE

Re-hook the viewer about to scroll. New fact, person, or place.

## CHOICE
1:30–2:05

**The hero acts. It costs something.**

WRITER RULE

Active decision, not reaction. Show the cost on the face.

## PAYOFF
2:05–2:22

**Answer the hook question, but differently than expected.**

WRITER RULE

Open one question, pay off a connected one. A real mini-reward.

## CLIFF
2:22–2:30

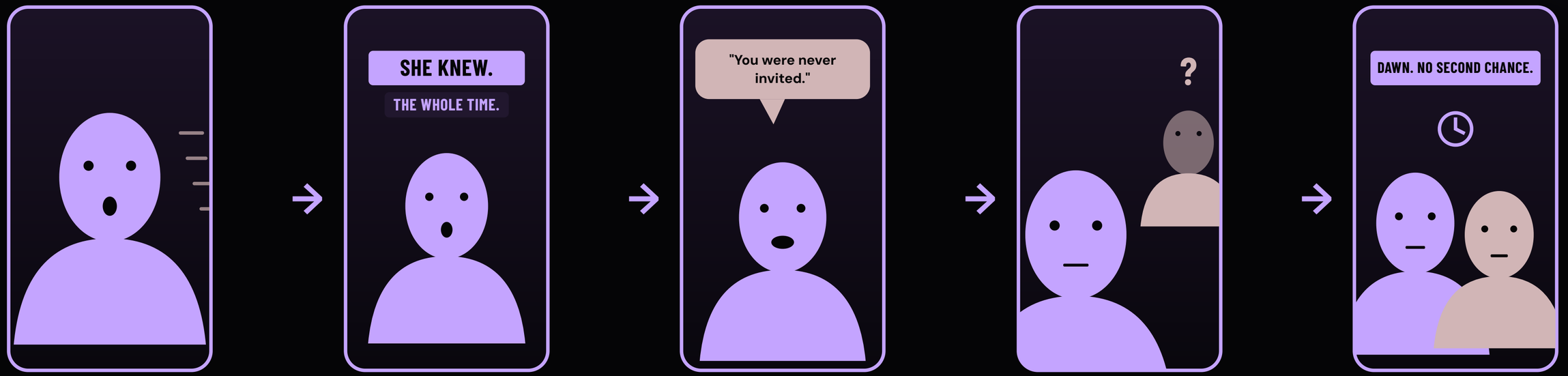
**Cut on the loaded moment.**

WRITER RULE

Unfinished line, new fact, or a held look. Never explain it.

# Five seconds to earn the next ten

The hook is not an intro. It is the most interesting moment of the episode, shown first, with a question attached.




**Already moving**
Face or action in frame 1. No fade-in, no logo.

**Text hook lands**
Big on-screen line. Readable muted.

**First line + sound hit**
Short, loaded, 8 words or less.

**The question forms**
A second element appears. Viewer asks why.

**Stakes are clear**
Who wants what, and what is the clock.

## SIX HOOK FORMULAS

Examples are placeholders. The writer swaps in the film's own moments.

### MID-CRISIS

Open on the worst moment. Explain later.

Hand on the door. The alarm is already ringing.

### FORBIDDEN LINE

Someone says what nobody should say.

"You were never supposed to wake up."

### STATUS SHOCK

A person exposed, crowned, or cast out.

The whole room goes silent, then looks at her.

### WRONG IMAGE

One impossible detail in a normal frame.

Snow falling inside the house.

### CLOCK

Tell the viewer what is about to break.

"The gates close at dawn."

### CALLBACK

Open on last episode's last frame, then flip it.

Same look. Opposite meaning.

**AVOID** Title cards · slow establishing shots · characters introducing themselves · "Previously on…" montages · starting calm "to build" · key info only in the score

# Eight rules that make vertical work

None of these change the story. They change how the story is cut, staged, and ended.



## RE-HOOK EVERY 15–20 s

New info, new place, new sound, or a reversal. If 20 seconds pass and nothing changes, cut or twist.



## ONE WANT PER EPISODE

The hero wants one thing. Every beat pushes for it or against it.



## SHORT LINES

About 8 words max. One idea per line. If a look, action, or prop can say it, cut the line.



## WORKS MUTED

Many people watch without sound. Story must read from picture + captions. Sound adds, never carries alone.



## VERTICAL STAGING

Faces and hands, not landscapes. One or two characters per frame. Depth: foreground, hero, threat behind.



## EVERY EPISODE IS EPISODE 1

One recap line in the first 20 s. A new viewer has to be able to enter anywhere in the series.



## CLOSE ONE LOOP, OPEN ONE

Answer the hook question. Plant a bigger one. Track open loops so none are forgotten.



## RESPECT THE SAFE ZONES

Keep faces and key text away from the top band, bottom band, and right rail where app UI sits.

## FIVE WAYS TO END AN EPISODE

The cliffhanger does not need an explosion. It needs a question the viewer feels.

### UNFINISHED LINE

**“I’m not—”**

Cut mid-word.

### NEW FACT

**“He’s not her brother.”**

One sentence. Hard cut.

### LOADED LOOK

**Hold the face for 2 s.**

Silence is the cut.

### IMPOSSIBLE CHOICE

**Two doors. One clock.**

Show both options.

### ARRIVAL

**The door opens. Someone is there.**

Reveal, don’t explain.

# Same story. New shape.

The film does not change. The writer slices it at its natural turns and rebuilds each slice as an episode.

## THE WRITER'S PROCESS

**1**
**Mark the turns**
Read the film script and mark every moment where something changes.

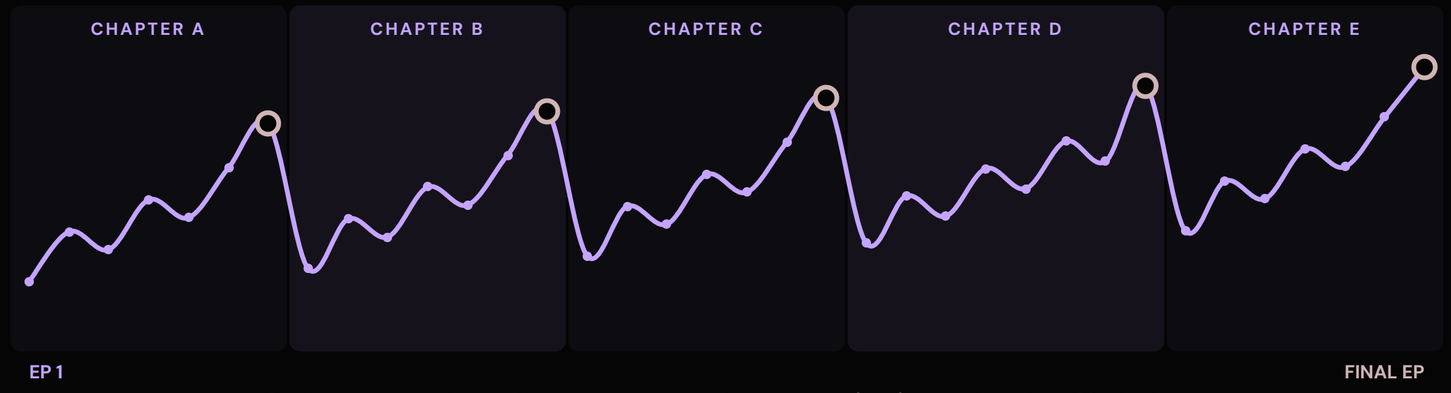
**2**
**Cut at the turns**
One scene becomes 1–3 episodes. Cut where the question is loudest.

**3**
**Rebuild the opening**
Move the strongest image or line of each scene to the first 5 seconds.

**4**
**Add recap + midpoint**
One recap line near 0:10. One reversal near 1:15.

**5**
**Sharpen the ending**
Turn the last beat into one of the five cliffhangers.

## THE SEASON LADDER




Small peaks every episode. Bigger turn at the end of each chapter (rose). Illustration shows 36 episodes.

**SPINE** moves the plot forward **HEART** deepens a relationship **SPIKE** set piece or big reveal **Never two quiet episodes in a row.**

> **Length math at 2:30** 15 eps ≈ 38 min · 20 eps ≈ 50 min · 36 eps ≈ 90 min · 50 eps ≈ 125 min. Pick the count from what the story needs. Do not pad.

## EPISODE SHEET

ONE PER EPISODE

| | |
|---|---|
| EP # · CHAPTER · TYPE | Spine / Heart / Spike |
| HOOK (0–5 s) | Image + line + on-screen text |
| RECAP LINE | 12 words or fewer |
| WANT → OBSTACLE | One want. One thing in the way. |
| TWIST (~1:15) | What flips? New fact, person, or place. |
| CHOICE + COST | What the hero does. What it costs. |
| PAYOFF | How the hook question is answered. |
| CLIFFHANGER | Type + the exact last frame |
| LOOPS | Closed in this ep · opened for next |
| LIMITS | 2 locations · 3 characters max |

### BEFORE IT GOES TO PRODUCTION

- ✓ Hook works in 5 s
- ✓ Recap line present
- ✓ A change every 20 s
- ✓ Hook answered, new loop opened
- ✓ Reads with sound off